Brand Success Redefined:

An Analysis of the Interrelationships among Various Brand Dimensions

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Abstract

Brands have become a vital part of the marketing strategy of any organization, the future of firms' lies in branding. Successful brands are like a motivating force containing enough energy to enlighten distant territories holding colossal appeal for consumers. This is a powerful force behind branding. This huge accretion of consumer pulling control works beyond brands conventional borders. Nowadays the entire progress of branding strategy is altering. Presently the brand development management is shifting from line branding to enterprise branding. This means that the management requires more thrust within the organization compared to how it has worked earlier. Aaker and Keller (1990) studied the consumer evaluations on brand attitude formation. Several replication studies have been conducted since which led to the opening of new branding horizons. This study is an endeavour to investigate into the various dimensions leading to a perfect brand success model. Brand awareness, Brand attitude, level of quality, satisfaction levels were the variables measured, to name a few. The results showed a strong relationship between awareness and attitude, awareness, brand attitude and usage, quality of the brands and satisfaction from brands. The different interaction effects among the brand attributes will be analyzed in-depth to identify the important variables and to build an empirical model leading to ultimate brand success.

Key Words: Brand Dimensions, Perception of Fit, Brand Attributes, Brand Associations

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Introduction

In the present competitive environment, it has become very difficult for the companies to keep in pace with the players in the market. The companies are compelled to regulate according to the market needs and should keep on improvising their activities. It is a fact that many companies do not take the time or effort to take proper responsibility of creating and enhancing its corporate identity. This often leads to a failure of the organization and the company's ability to compete decreases (Selame and Selame, 1988). The vision of a company is not to create a single sale contract with the customer but to generate brands that remain in the top of the mind recall. A company, who communicates to the consumer must be concerned with how the consumer develops its likes and dislikes, so a strong, favorable and positive preference for the brand is installed (Alreck and Settle, 1999). Branding strategies are employed by companies with a motive to increase returns and to commandeer consumer mind space by trying to enter new markets. The significance of brands as a rejuvenating factor has gained impetus in the marketing discipline and has become crucial for examining the branding strategies in the global scenario. Ries (2003), Parameswaran (2004) and Haigh (2004) have given a comprehensive definition of Brand whereby it is first a logo, secondly a larger collection of trade names and associated intellectual property rights further broken down in to knowledge: business process intangibles and relationship intangibles and thirdly it encompasses within itself a holistic company or an executive brand. Successful brands are like a motivating force containing enough energy to enlighten distant territories holding colossal appeal for consumers. This is a powerful force behind branding. This huge accretion of consumer pulling control works beyond brands conventional borders. Nowadays the entire progress of branding strategy is altering. Presently the brand development management is shifting from line branding to enterprise branding. This means that the management requires more thrust within the organization compared to how it has worked earlier.

Brand Dimensions – A Theoretical Framework

A proliferation of brands can be seen in the market place in the last decade. The market is throbbing with different types of brands meant to meet the needs of its consumers. Brands are built and developed to magnetize consumers and to sustain them thereby increasing its value, image, credibility, lifestyle and so on. Branding strategies are techniques to develop a long

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lasting, differential advantage by playing it on the ultimate consumers. Branding reduces the risk consumers' face when they have to buy products that they know hardly anything about. Thus branding strategies are more on the rise in the marketing arena now. This ultimately leads to the understanding that brand dimensions and their interrelationships are crucial for brand success.

Various dimensions that lead to brand success have been identified such as Perception of Fit, Brand Attributes and Brand Associations. These have been heavily drawn from literature on brand management and various other branding studies.

The perception of fit may be defined by the extent of brand awareness and reputation of the firm. Reputation of a firm is the image enjoyed by it as a result of consumer perceptions of quality revolving around the brand. The chances of success of brands having higher perceived quality are more than brands having lesser perceived quality. A strong feeling of awareness of brands among consumers also strengthens the position of the brands in the market. Brand attributes are product related and non-product related. Product related attributes are ingredients necessary for performing the product or service function sought by the consumers which is physical in nature. Non-product related attributes refer to the external aspects of the product or service that relate to its purchase or consumption. These attributes include elements like pricing, packing, advertising, marketing and promotional measures of the brand. Associations to the brand are informational links of the attributes, benefits and attitudes about the brand in the memory of a consumer and it reveals the meaning of the brand to the consumer. Thus the uniqueness in the knowledge structure of the brand in the consumer's mind helps in creating a strong and stable relationship between the consumer and the brand. The brand associations are made distinct through the attitude towards the brand, usage of the brand, quality of the brand and the level of satisfaction towards the brand.

This study is an endeavor to investigate into the various dimensions leading to a perfect brand success model.

Review of the Literature

During the last decade there have been a number of research studies addressing consumer evaluations of Brands Alreck and Settle (1999), Ries (2003), Parameswaran (2004) and Haigh (2004) and their impact of different extensions on the core brand (Aaker and Keller (1990),

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Romeo (1991)). Once the consumers grow a positive feeling of a brand they do not easily acknowledge substitutes (Rooney, 1995).

Majority of Brand Literature has focused upon brand extensions and not the interrelationships among various brand dimensions (Aaker and Keller (1990); Sunde and Brodie (1993), Bottomley and Doyle (1996). The following studies focuses on perception of fit as a brand dimension for brand success. The studies on conceptualization and evidence on the two dimensions of fit construct by Park *et al.* (1991), Park and McCarthy (1993), Bhat and Reddy (1997 and 2001), and Swaminathan et al. (2008). According to Lane (2000) positive consumer mood may improve fit perceptions. Boush (1993), Pryor and Brodie (1998), Bridges *et al.* (2000), Kim *et al.* (2001) studies reveals Brand advertising can improve fit perceptions including exposure, priming, distancing and improving association salience. Romeo (1991), Keller and Aaker (1992), Park and McCarthy (1993), Milberg *et al.* (1997), and Gurhan-Canli and Maheswaran (1998).

The perception of Fit is one facet that has been tested and proved time and again. Studies of Aaker and Keller (1990), Park *et al.* (1991), Keller and Aaker (1992), Dacin and Smith (1994) and Bhat and Reddy (1997) have attempted to find out the various aspects of Fit perception phenomenon which is instrumental in deciding the consumer's attitude towards brands.

Aaker and Keller (1990), Boush and Loken (1991), Keller and Aaker (1992), Sunde and Brodie (1993), Broniarczyk and Alba (1994), Nijssen and Hartman (1994), Holden and Barwise (1995), Bottomley and Doyle (1996), Bhat and Reddy (1997 and 2001), Falherty and Pappas (2000), Bottomley and Holden (2001) studied various aspects of Brand Associations such as quality, role of parent brand strength and non product related brand associations on market share. Types of associations such as knowledge accessibility and effect of fit on reciprocal attitude transfer by Reddy *et al.* (1994), Ahluwalia and Gurhan-Canli (2000), Romeo (1991), Milberg *et al*. (1997). The studies examined various factors contributing to the measurement of brand association as a dimension.

The research on specific product attributes by Glynn and Brodie (1998), and Bhat and Reddy (2001) and on marketing strategy such as advertising exposure by Morrin (1999) contributes to the measurement of other dimension of brand attribute.

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Several replication studies have been conducted since which led to the opening of new branding horizons. Having reviewed the various studies on brand success and their measurement of various brand dimensions the present study focuses on the success of the brand and the interrelationships of various brand dimensions which leads to the successful brand.

Methodology

The study on interrelationships among brand dimensions for brand success was conducted on consumers of FMCG Brands. A structured schedule was designed and 360 respondents were randomly selected for interview from the four major cities of South India viz., Chennai, Cochin, Bangalore and Hyderabad. The brands were selected by using data obtained from Brand Equity's 'Most Trusted' FMCG brands of 2008 which is a ranking of brands published by Economic Times every year. The data on the ranking of brands are prepared on the basis of A C Neilson retail audit survey. The top fifty FMCGs were selected and a pre-test was conducted among 100 respondents to rate the ten most popular FMCGs among the top 50 FMCGs. The brands selected for the study were Colgate (Toothpaste), Vicks (Vapourub), Britannia (Biscuits), Dettol (Antiseptic Lotion), Ponds (Face Cream), Amul (Milk), Ujala (Liquid Blue), Nirma (Washing Powder), Johnson and Johnson (Baby Soap) and Cinthol (Bathsoap). The variables selected for the study were Perception of Fit (Bousch and Loken, 1991, Lahiri, 2002) measured by Brand awareness Boush (1993), Pryor and Brodie (1998), Bridges *et al.* (2000), Kim *et al.* (2001) and reputation of the firm Aaker and Keller (1990), Dacin and Smith (1994), Park *et. al* (2001). The second important factor selected for the study was Brand Attributes (Aaker and Keller 1990, Bhat and Reddy, 2001) which was in turn measured by Packing, Pricing (Tulin Erdem, Michael P. Keane, Baohong Sun, 2008), Advertising (Nakamoto *et. al,* 1993, Balachander and Ghose, 2003), Promotional measures (Loken and John, 1993, Swaminathan *et al*, 2008) and Marketing (Klink and Smith 1997, Ambler and Styles, 1997) of the Brand. The third and the final variable used for the study was Brand Associations (Reddy *et. al*, 1994) which includes level of quality (Zeithaml V.A, 1988), Brand Attitude (Echo Wen Wan and Sternthal, 2008), level of Satisfaction from the Brand (Vijay K Pandey et al, 2008) and usage level of the brand (Ahluwalia and Gurhan Canli, 2000). The reliability test was run to find out the reliability and consistency of each variable decided in the schedule. The Cronbach alpha value was 0.75. The scale measuring the various factors were

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grouped to find the average mean score and ranked. Partial correlation was used to measure the interrelationships among the various brand dimensions.

Analysis & Interpretation

Branding means much more than just giving a brand name and signaling to the outside world that such a product has been stamped with the mark and imprint of the organization. The real aim and object of the concept "Branding" can be gathered from the following analyses. The average mean scores for all the three factors namely Perception of Fit, Brand Attributes and Brand Associations were calculated and ranked for all the brands as shown in Table 1. From the table, it is observed that for all the brands Perception of Fit mean score ranks first followed by brand attributes and finally brand associations.

TABLE I: Average Mean Scores and Ranks of Brand Dimensions

Particulars	Perfection of Fit	Brand Attributes	Brand Associates
Colgate	4.52	3.98	3.89
Vicks	4.44	3.69	3.59
Britannia	4.48	3.77	3.68
Dettol	4.31	3.75	3.65
Ponds	4.25	3.33	3.02
Amul	4.17	3.21	2.88
Ujala	4.13	3.72	3.60
Nirma	4.19	3.44	3.06
Johnson & Joh	4.34	3.60	3.49
Cinthol	4.33	3.59	3.42
RANK	**1**	**2**	**3**

The interrelationships among the various brand dimensions were analyzed using partial correlation and the results are shown in Table 2. All the brand dimensions show that there is a positive relationship among them except for the brand Nirma (Washing Powder) where Brand attribute is the controlling variable and the other two factors Perception of Fit and Brand Association shows a negative relationship. It was observed that the consumers prefer the brand taking in to consideration the reputation of the firm rather than the level of quality, brand

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attitude, the usage level etc. Nirma (Washing Powder) having positioned itself for the middle income groups, the price is the major factor for consumer decision making.

Table 2: PARTIAL CORRELATION - INTERRELATIONSHIPS AMONG VARIOUS BRAND DIMENSIONS									
	Control Variable	Factor 1	Factor 2	Control Variable	Factor 1	Factor 3	Control Variable	Factor 2	Factor 3
Name of the Product	Brand Association	Perception of Fit	Brand Attributes	Brand Attributes	Perception of Fit	Brand Association	Perception of Fit	Brand Association	Brand Attributes
COLGATE	CV1	0.350*	0.350*	CV2	0.224*	0.224*	CV3	0.569*	0.569*
VICKSVAPORUB	CV1	0.415*	0.415*	CV2	0.110**	0.110**	CV3	0.630*	0.630*
BRITANNIA	CV1	0.477*	0.477*	CV2	0.038	0.038	CV3	0.640*	0.640*
DETTOL	CV1	0.287*	0.287*	CV2	0.222*	0.222*	CV3	0.296*	0.296*
PONDS	CV1	0.593*	0.593*	CV2	0.055	0.055	CV3	0.599*	0.599*
AMUL	CV1	0.477*	0.477*	CV2	0.041	0.041	CV3	0.679*	0.679*
UJALA	CV1	0.283*	0.283*	CV2	0.174*	0.174*	CV3	0.616*	0.616*
NIRMA	CV1	0.562*	0.562*	CV2	-0.047	-0.047	CV3	0.632*	0.632*
JOHNSON & JOHNSON	CV1	0.350*	0.350*	CV2	0.205*	0.205*	CV3	0.618*	0.618*
CINTHOL	CV1	0.399*	0.399*	CV2	0.109**	0.109**	CV3	0.636*	0.636*

*1% Significance, ** 5% Significance

Figure 1 shows a conceptual model showcasing the important ingredients to brand success and their interrelationship.

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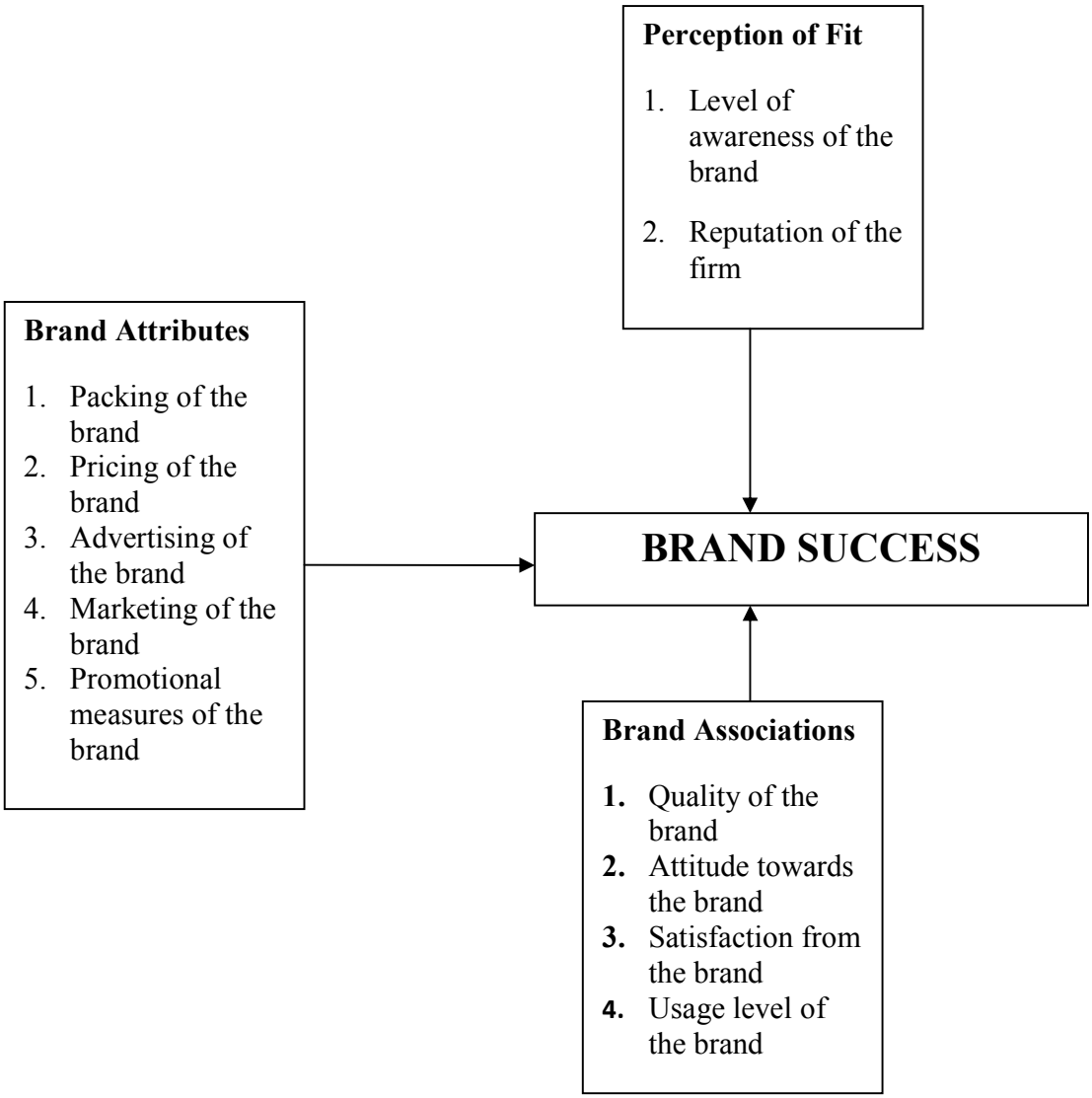
Fig 1: Brand Dimensions contributing to Brand Success



Conclusion

The Indian business groups presently find themselves placed in a convoluted and turbulent situation owing primarily to multiple players in the market, growth of the economy, awareness level of the consumers and a variety of other factors contributing to this situation. In the present competitive scenario, marketers are always trying to evolve novel strategies to overcome fresh challenges. Time tested strategies are largely relied upon by them to achieve optimal market

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growth; but market situation has to be delved into in detail before designing and executing fresh strategies. This study leads to the conclusion that the three essential elements - perception of fit, brand attributes and brand associations are indeed irrefutable for a brand's success. An in-depth study of these essential elements by companies is inevitable for the successful launch of brands. Not only should the already existing favourable attitudes towards the brand be instilled but steps should be taken to enhance brand image by capturing consumer mind space.

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